Oliver Herbert

CELLIST · BIOGRAPHY

Oliver Herbert is a cellist who performs as a soloist with orchestras, as a chamber musician, and in programs of his own. Alongside the cello classics, he plays rarely heard works and new music. He received a 2021 Avery Fisher Career Grant.

As a concerto soloist he has appeared across the Americas and Europe with conductors including Michael Tilson Thomas, Giancarlo Guerrero, Juanjo Mena, Reinhard Goebel, Teddy Abrams, Alexander Shelley and Alexander Prior. He made his San Francisco Symphony debut at the orchestra's All San Francisco Concert in 2018 and returned the following year for his subscription debut under Tilson Thomas, of which San Francisco Classical Voice wrote of his "full-throated but never indulgent tone, crisp yet expressive phrasing… youthful but magisterial." Early recognition came through an open audition to perform Strauss's Don Quixote on the Chicago Symphony Orchestra's Family Matinee Series. He played the work the same season with the Curtis Symphony Orchestra, and the Philadelphia Inquirer heard "deeply moving vocal inflections in extreme ranges" and "all the depth of an established soloist."

His own projects have included programs for Deutschlandfunk's Raderbergkonzerte and the TICA Festival in Hong Kong, a sustained focus on the music of Schnittke, Paul Desenne and Ruth Crawford Seeger, and premieres of works by Helena Winkelman, Žibuoklė Martinaitytė and Andrew Moses.

As a chamber musician he appears at Marlboro Music, the Moritzburg and Rheingau Festivals, La Jolla SummerFest, ChamberFest Cleveland, the Philadelphia Chamber Music Society, the Utrecht Festival, the 92nd Street Y and Ravinia. Highlights include a North American tour with Mitsuko Uchida and musicians from Marlboro, ending at Carnegie Hall, and collaborations with Janine Jansen, Jonathan Biss and Tabea Zimmermann.

His recordings include Haydn's D major Concerto with the San Francisco Symphony and Michael Tilson Thomas, released by Warner Classics among the highlights of Tilson Thomas's final season as music director; Frame of Mind (2020), with pianist Xiaohui Yang, pairing Fauré's two sonatas with Janáček's Pohádka; and Beethoven's Triple Concerto, recorded live with Dora Bratchkova, Olga Zado and the Mannheimer Philharmoniker under Boian Videnoff (MaPhil Records, 2026).

He has received the Verbier Festival's Jean-Nicolas Firmenich Prize and top prizes at the Lutosławski International Cello Competition and the Klein and Stulberg International String Competitions, and in 2025 he was selected for the Orpheum Foundation's program for young soloists. He has been featured on PBS's Now Hear This, NPR's From the Top and WQXR, and on German radio including WDR, Deutschlandfunk, HR and ARD.

Born in San Francisco, he studied at the Colburn School and the Curtis Institute of Music with Clive Greensmith, Carter Brey, Peter Wiley and Pamela Frank. In 2026 he graduated from Kronberg Academy, where he studied with Frans Helmerson with the support of the Nanno Lenz Patronage. He plays a Guadagnini cello that once belonged to Antonio Janigro, on loan from the Janigro family.

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